

Session 42: A Tale of Two Shelters

Key Takeaways

- During the feast of Sukkot, the Israelites built tents called *sukkahs*, Eden shelters made out of fruit branches. They didn't build them to provide their own Eden but to remind themselves of God's provision of Eden blessings.
- Jonah builds his own *sukkah*, a miniature city of protection, and refuses God's invitation to join Eden. God responds by sending a plant to shelter him.
- Jonah's actions are hyperlinked to Cain's building of the first city of protection because he didn't accept God's protection. When humans don't trust God's protection, they become violent and elevate their own protection at the expense of others, creating cities of blood.

Jonah's Shelter and God's Worm: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 4:5-8

Jonah's Shelter From the Sun

- A
- a 5 And Jonah went out from **the city** ,
a' and he sat from the east of **the city** ,
b and he made for himself there **a tent** ,
b'' and he sat under it in **the shade** ,
a'' until he might see what would happen to **the city** .

God Provides Plant Shelter

- B
- a 6 **And Yahweh Elohim appointed a** **qiqayon** and it arose from over Jonah,
b to be a **shade** upon his head,
b' to deliver him from his evil,
a' and Jonah rejoiced over the **qiqayon** , a great rejoicing.

God Ruins Plant Shelter

- B'
- 7 **And God appointed a worm**
at the rising of the dawn on the next day,
and it **struck** the **qiqayon**
and it withered.

No Shelter From the Sun

A'⁸ And it came about as the sun shone
and **God appointed an east wind**, a hot one,
and the sun **struck** the upon the head of Jonah.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

A and A' provide the outer frame that contrasts Jonah's provision of his own shelter with his lack of shelter that exposes him to the burning sun.

B and B' provide a two-step sequence for the provision of a divine shelter and God's destruction of that shelter. Jonah's experience of building and losing his shelter frames the inner scenes where God provides and then ruins the plant.

Jonah's Journey East and His Self-Made Shelter

The opening line in 4:5 recalls the analogies with Cain in Genesis 4:1 and 4:4 and develops them further. Jonah's departure from Nineveh is depicted as a self-inflicted exile like Cain's.

Jonah in Jonah 4

Jonah 4:1 Instructor's Translation

And [God's showing mercy to Nineveh] was evil to Jonah, a great evil, and there was heat-anger to him (ל ויחר-).

Jonah 4:4 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh said, "Is it doing good that there is heat-anger to you (חרה ההיטב לך)?"

Jonah 4:5 Instructor's Translation

And Jonah went out (ויצא) from the city, and he sat from the east of the city (מקדם וישב) and made for himself a sukkah, and he sat (וישב) under it.

Cain in Genesis 4

Genesis 4:4b-5 NASB*

⁴ And Yahweh regarded Abel and his offering, ⁵ but Cain and his offering he did not regard, and there was heat-anger to Cain (ל ויחר).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 4:6-7 Instructor's Translation

⁶ "Why is there heat-anger to you (לך חרה)? ⁷ Isn't it the case that if you do good (תיטיב), there is exaltation?"

Genesis 4:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ And Cain went out (וַיֵּצֵא) from before the face of Yahweh, and he sat (וַיֵּשֶׁב) in the land of Nod, to the east of Eden (עֵדֶן קְדֵמַת) ... ¹⁷ And he built a city, and called the name of the city according to the name of his son "Enoch."

Jonah is being likened to Cain, who rejected Yahweh's offer of forgiveness and protection and journeyed east of Eden to build his own protection in the form of a city (this is itself a wordplay hyperlink contrast to God "building help" for the man in Gen. 2:18: "city" עִיר / "help" עֵזֶר).

Jonah's *sukkah* (סֻכָּה) activates a whole network of associations with God's provision of Eden protection for his people in the wilderness.

The Feast of Sukkot

From the 15th to the 21st of the seventh month, the Israelites were to celebrate an extended seven-day Sabbath. The ritual practice is about a self-imposed, symbolic "exile" from their homes to dwell in a *sukkah*. The description is packed with Eden imagery and symbolizes how God provided Israel with glimpses of Eden during their sojourn in the desert.

Leviticus 23:40, 42 Instructor's Translation

⁴⁰ And you will take for yourself ... from the fruit of the tree (פְּרִי עֵץ), a majestic one, branches of palm leaves, and a bough of a tree of leaf and poplars by a river, and you will rejoice before Yahweh your God for seven days. ... ⁴² In Sukkot you will sit (יֵשֶׁב) for seven days.

Eden imagery

- Genesis 3:6: Taking from the fruit of the tree
- Genesis 1:11/2:9: Fruit trees
- Genesis 2:9-10: The tree of life is next to the river of life
- Genesis 2:1-3: Creation is completed within seven days
- Genesis 2:15: God placed humanity in the garden

In Deuteronomy 16, the feast of Sukkot was a time for extreme hospitality for outsiders to Israel. This explains why in Zechariah 14, the in-gathering of the nations to worship Yahweh in the new Jerusalem takes place during the feast of Sukkot.

Deuteronomy 16:13-15 NASB*

¹³ You shall celebrate the feast of Sukkot seven days after you have gathered in from your threshing floor and your wine vat; ¹⁴ and you shall have joy (שִׂמְחָה) in your feast, you and your son and your daughter and your male and female servants and the Levite and **the immigrant and the orphan and the widow** who are in your towns. ¹⁵ Seven days you shall celebrate a feast to the LORD your God in the place which the LORD chooses, because the LORD your God will bless you in all your produce and in all the work of your hands, so that **you will be altogether joyful** (שִׂמְחָה).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Zechariah 14:16 NASB

Then it will come about that any who are left of all the nations that went against Jerusalem will go up from year to year to worship the King, the LORD of hosts, and to celebrate the feast of Sukkot.

Moses directed Israel to gather during every seventh feast of Sukkot and read aloud from the Torah. This practice was carried out by those returning from exile in Babylon in the time of Ezra and Nehemiah.

Nehemiah 8:14-18 NASB*

¹⁴ They found written in the law how the LORD had commanded through Moses that the sons of Israel should live in booths during the feast of the seventh month. ¹⁵ So they proclaimed and circulated a proclamation in all their cities and in Jerusalem, saying, "Go out to the hills, and bring olive branches and wild olive branches, myrtle branches, palm branches and branches of other leafy trees, to make sukkot, as it is written." ¹⁶ So the people went out and brought them and made sukkot for themselves, each on his roof, and in their courts and in the courts of the house of God, and in the square at the Water Gate and in the square at the Gate of Ephraim. ¹⁷ The entire assembly of those who had returned from the captivity made sukkot and lived in them. The sons of Israel had indeed not done so from the days of Joshua the son of Nun to that day. And there was great rejoicing (מאד גדולה שמחה). ¹⁸ He read from the book of the law of God daily, from the first day to the last day.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Recall Jonah's "great rejoicing" (גדולה שמחה) over the plant that God provides in [Jonah 4:6](#).

Deuteronomy 31:10-11 NASB*

¹⁰ Then Moses commanded them, saying, "At the end of seven years, at the time of the year of remission of debts, at the feast of Sukkot, ¹¹ when all Israel comes to appear before the LORD your God at the place which he will choose, you shall read this law in front of all Israel in their hearing."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Sukkot, the Temple, and God's Presence

The ark of the covenant dwelt in a "tent" (אהל), also called a "shelter" (*sukkah* סכה).

2 Samuel 7:2 NIV*

"Here I am, living in a house of cedar, while the ark of God sits (ישב) in the midst of a (אהל) **tent**."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Samuel 11:11 NIV*

Uriah said to David, "The ark and Israel and Judah are sitting (ישב) in **shelters** (*sukkot* סככות), and my lord Joab and the servants of my lord are camping in the open field."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In the Psalms, God's provision of protection is called a shelter.

Psalm 31:19-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁹ How great is your goodness ...
for those who take refuge in you.

²⁰ You conceal them in the secret place of your face-presence ...
you hide them in a **shelter** (סכה).

Sukkot as Jerusalem and the Messianic Jerusalem

Jerusalem as the seat of David's kingdom is likened to a shelter in the Prophets. Thus, the new Jerusalem of the messianic age is called a shelter, which God will build after the full restoration from exile.

Isaiah 1:8 NASB*

The daughter of Zion is left like a **shelter** (*sukkah* סכה) in a vineyard.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Amos 9:11-12 NASB*

¹¹ "In that day I will raise up the fallen **shelter** (סכה) of David,
and wall up its breaches;

I will also raise up its ruins
and rebuild it as in the days of old;

¹² that they may possess the remnant of Edom
and all the nations who are called by my name,"
declares the LORD who does this.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 4:2-6 NASB*

² In that day, the branch of the LORD will be beautiful and glorious, and the fruit of the earth will be the pride and the adornment of the survivors of Israel. ³ It will come about that he who is left in Zion and remains in Jerusalem will be called holy—everyone who is recorded for life in Jerusalem. ⁴ When the Lord has washed away the filth of the daughters of Zion and purged the bloodshed of Jerusalem from her midst, **by a wind of judgment and a wind of burning,** ⁵ **then the LORD will create** over the whole area of Mount Zion and over her assemblies a cloud by day, even smoke, and the brightness of a flaming fire by night; for over all the glory will be a canopy (חפה). ⁶ **There will be a shelter** (סכה) for **shade** (לצל) **from the heat by day**, and refuge and protection from the storm and the rain.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These texts make clear that the renewal of Jerusalem in the messianic age will be an act of God. He will create the ultimate *sukkah* for his people to protect them from the heat of the sun, which is likened to threats from Israel's enemies (see [Isa. 25:4-5](#) for a development of the metaphor of "enemies as heat from the sun").

Conclusions on the Sukkot Theme

These key themes surrounding Sukkot (celebrating a new Eden, in-gathering of the nations, restoration of God's presence in the temple, the renewal of the Davidic kingship) are all brought together in Jonah 4.

Consider Jonah's appearance in 2 Kings 14:25-26, where he prophesied the restoration of Israel's borders to their Eden-like proportions. Assyria was the nation that reduced those very boundaries (as Amos prophesied in Amos 6:14), so it makes perfect sense that Jonah would leave Nineveh to create a "pseudo-Eden" that rekindles the hopes for a new David and a new Jerusalem. But this messianic age is for himself only, a last resort to thwart or counter Yahweh's plans.

God Provides Jonah with a Plant

God Provides Plant Shelter

B

- a 6 And Yahweh Elohim appointed a **qiqayon** and it arose from over Jonah,
b to be a **shade** upon his head,
b' to deliver him from his evil,
a' and Jonah rejoiced over the **qiqayon**, a great rejoicing.

Jonah 4:5-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

4:6a

In all of ancient Hebrew, the *qiqayon* plant name appears only here (קִיקְיֹון). Certainty about the species of plant has eluded scholars for the entire history of interpretation, and one suspects that the real point of its mention is not to discover its botanical identity!

Attempts to Identify the Plant (see Robinson, "Jonah's Qiqayon Plant")

The oldest translations render the Hebrew term with "gourd."

- Old Greek: *κολόκυνθα*
- Old Latin: *cucurbita*
- Syriac Peshitta: *qar'a'*

This was adopted in older English translations (eventually KJV, RV). Some ancient translations rendered it as some kind of ivy.

- Symmachus: *κισσος* There is evidence that Jerome's Vulgate, *hedera*, refers to a castor oil plant. Tyndale, the first English translation, rendered the term "as it were a wild vine."
- Coverdale Bible: "wylde vyne."

The Akkadian term *kukkanitu* was used in Assyrian texts (Assyria!) to refer to plants in the royal garden. It is more than likely that Jonah's author chose a real botanical term, one that sounds like the language of the Assyrians. But there may be more to it.

The plant's name sounds exactly like words in two related texts from earlier in Jonah.

Jonah 1:14 NASB

[Sailors who throw Jonah into the sea] "Don't put innocent blood upon us."

Naqi' (נָקִיא): "we will vomit"

Jonah 1:17, 2:10 NASB

1:17 And Yahweh appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah ... 2:10 And Yahweh spoke to the fish and he vomited Jonah.

Yonah' + qa - יונה + קא

Jonah 4:6 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh Elohim appointed a **qiqayon**.

Qi-qa-yon = "vomiting, he vomited Jonah"

"*Qiqayon* may be a extremely rare word used here to give an exotic flavor to the story. In Jonah 2:11 the author had described how the great fish that God had deployed ... had spewed Jonah out (*qa'*). The plant in Jonah chapter 4 has a similar function to the fish, and this fact may have suggested to the author the rare plant name that is visually similar to the word 'spew.'"

Robinson, Bernard P. (1985). "Jonah's Qiqayon Plant." *Giessen*, vol. 97, 3. 402.

4:6b

"And it went up from over Jonah, to be shade over his head, and to deliver him from his evil."

What is Jonah's "evil?" This is most likely a reference back to Jonah 4:1: "And it [God's mercy toward the repentant Ninevites] was evil to Jonah, a great evil." This plant is God's strategy for relieving Jonah of God forgiving his enemies. But how exactly? We have to keep reading.

The two phrases, "to be shade over his head" and "to deliver him from evil," are two parallel lines in the central symmetry of the entire verse (A B B' A). This prompts the reader to ponder a conceptual analogy between shade and deliverance.

4:6c

"And Jonah rejoiced a great joy over the *qiqayon*."

This is the only time Jonah is happy in the entire story, and it concerns a plant that benefits only him as he sulks in his pitiful anger.

Jonah's "great joy" (גְּדוּלָה שִׂמְחָה) echoes a phrase commonly associated with the feast of Sukkot, which is to be accompanied by "great joy" (Ezra 8:17; also Deut. 16:15).

"Jonah ... crawl[s] under the *sukkâ* that he builds in order to benefit from its shade. Soon, however, God directs the *qîqâyôn* to shade him from above his head. The pun is directional, depending on a contrasting

location for this 'shade' (ṣēl), but it is also versatile: through this divine act meant 'to deliver him from his distress,' Jonah acquires a satisfying response to his complaint. This plant, marvelously rising above his head, is a sign of a new equilibrium between him and God, of a renewed understanding between the two ... From Jonah's perspective, the story can end now on this happy note: Nineveh and its fate are no longer central to Jonah; his difference with God is now resolved. From God's standpoint, however, there is still the matter of educating a prophet on divine mercy. Now that Jonah has turned the issue into a personal, if not physical, problem; now that he has come out from his deep funk, God will readily turn to pedagogic instruments that are too obvious to be misunderstood by Jonah, and by us as well."

Adapted from Sasson, Jack M. (1995). [Jonah](#). Yale University Press. 298.

Reflection Question

In [chapter 4](#), we are presented with an object lesson where Jonah builds a shelter, God provides shelter, Jonah's shelter is taken away, and then God removes his shelter. What is the point of this lesson? Why are these object lessons so helpful for teaching?